GAMSA · Gender-Affirming Medicines South Australia

PBS Authority for testosterone in gender-affirming care: how it is worded

A one-page card for prescribers and pharmacists · gamsa.au/clinicians

The situation

There is no PBS listing for gender affirmation. Every PBS testosterone item is listed for androgen deficiency and needs an Authority prescription. Written as a private script, the same product can cost several times the co-payment (the full PBS price alone is $78 to $106), so the paperwork is the single biggest lever on what the patient pays.

Who can prescribe on the PBS

PBS information: the restriction's treatment criteria and prescribing instruction, as published (item 10205D)

"Must be treated by a specialist general paediatrician, specialist paediatric endocrinologist, specialist urologist, specialist endocrinologist or a Fellow of the Australasian Chapter of Sexual Health Medicine; or in consultation with one of these specialists; or have an appointment to be assessed by one of these specialists."
"The name of the specialist must be included in the authority application."

GAMSA's explanation: The specialist consultation only needs to happen once; that specialist's name can be used on later Authority applications. Once that is in place, a GP or nurse practitioner can write the PBS script.

The indication used

The Australian position statement (MJA 2019) uses the authority indication **"androgen deficiency due to an established testicular disorder"** (the statement's own words): the patient is treated by or in consultation (including by phone or email) with a paediatrician, endocrinologist, urologist or sexual health physician, whose name goes on the authority application.

Each PBS item page gives the full criteria (select **Criteria**). Use the androgen deficiency restriction for an established disorder, not the one for people aged 40 or over. Its criterion reads: "Patient must have an established pituitary or testicular disorder." Check the current wording at the time of prescribing.

Before the patient reaches the counter

- ☐ Specialist consultation or pending appointment documented, name recorded
- ☐ Authority obtained (online or phone) and number on the script
- ☐ Formulation and strength match the PBS item (long-acting undecanoate injection, gel or cream; short-acting injections are not PBS-listed)
- ☐ Patient told the script is PBS Authority, and what the wording will say

What the wording means, and does not mean

Read plainly, the indication describes a pituitary or testicular disorder that stops the body making enough testosterone. It is a listing written long before gender-affirming care was considered and never rewritten. It does not mean the prescription is wrong, that the prescriber has invented anything, or that the patient's entitlement or price is different.

A line to use at the counter

"The PBS has no listing written for gender-affirming care, so testosterone is subsidised under its androgen deficiency indication. The wording is a funding category, not a description of you. Your price and your entitlement are the same as for anyone on a PBS Authority script."

Other hormone medicines

Estradiol, spironolactone and cyproterone (its packs of 50) are General Schedule items and need no Authority. Estradiol patches are often in short supply; check gamsa.au/supply before telling a patient a product is unavailable.

Sources: Pharmaceutical Benefits Scheme item listings and restriction criteria for testosterone products (www.pbs.gov.au); Cheung AS et al. Position statement on the hormonal management of adult transgender and gender diverse individuals. Med J Aust 2019;211(3):127–133; AusPATH. Australian Standards of Care for Informed Consent Gender-Affirming Hormone Therapy, version 2 (2026), p33 (auspath.org.au). Patient explanation and references: gamsa.au/costs. Not medical advice; the PBS Schedule in force on the day governs.

From the PBS: the quoted criteria and instruction, item details and prices. Source: PBS Schedule, www.pbs.gov.au, extracted 6 November 2026 (restriction wording re-checked 7 November 2026); reproduced with permission of the Australian Government Department of Health, Disability and Ageing. The rest of this card is GAMSA's own explanation.

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